



Click. Snap. Magnetise?

How Xiaomi's Modular Optical System aims to change smartphone photography

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If you have ever explored the evolution of smartphone photography or tried to click pictures in tricky situations with limited resources as found on a smartphone, you would recognise the persistent challenge of balancing portability with image quality. The latest attempt to address this comes from Xiaomi, which recently unveiled a modular camera system for its smartphones at MWC 2025. Dubbed the "Modular Optical System," this prototype integrates a 100-megapixel Micro Four Thirds (MFT) sensor and a 35mm f/1.4 lens that magnetically attaches to compatible Xiaomi phones. While the concept of external camera modules isn't new – Sony's QX series, Kodak's PixPro, and others have tried

and failed – Xiaomi's approach, while reminiscent of previous attempts by brands like Sony, Olympus, and Motorola, introduces notable improve-

ments that may redefine how users interact with smartphone cameras. However, its limited compatibility raises questions about its mass-market appeal.

Read along to find out how Xiaomi's Modular Optical System could reshape the landscape of mobile photography –

A familiar idea, reimagined

If we trace back the history of attachable camera modules, Sony's QX series stands out as a cautionary tale. The Sony QX10 and QX100, launched in 2013, promised to bring DSLR-like quality to smartphones by integrating a high-quality sensor and lens into a detachable module. While they delivered on image quality, they faltered in execution. The reliance on Sony's PlayMemories app led to connectivity issues, slow response times, and frustrating user experiences.

Xiaomi, however, is taking a different route. Unlike Sony's solution, which functioned as an independent camera requiring a separate app, Xiaomi's Modular Optical System integrates seamlessly with its existing camera app. Through its proprietary LaserLink technology, the lens module locks onto the phone magnetically while drawing power and data directly from the device. This streamlines the user experience and eliminates the cumbersome pairing process that plagued Sony's QX series.



PlayMemories
Mobile

